

Based on the provided JSON files, here is a strategic decision model for the current event. All analysis is strictly limited to the information within the supplied documents.

Event: A U.S. reconnaissance plane discovered Soviet missile bases in Cuba, confirming the deployment of Soviet nuclear missiles.

This "Covert Detection" event immediately impacts the variables for both nations as defined in their effect_rules.

United States:Tension increases by 0.3.

Soviet Union:Tension increases by 0.45.

This initial surge in Tension sets the stage for more confrontational policy choices, as outlined in the Variable–Decision Matrix.json.

1. Strategic Alternatives for the United States

Based on the U.S. actor profiles, the following strategic alternatives are plausible:

Alternative 1: Naval Quarantine and Public Address

Rationale: This is President Kennedy's preferred initial course of action, aiming to "force the removal of Soviet nuclear missiles" through a "firm but measured" approach that is not an immediate act of war. It acts as a middle path, applying military pressure to satisfy the Department of Defense while leaving room for a diplomatic resolution favored by the State Department. A public address is necessary to secure domestic and international support and legitimize the action.

Next Event Triggers:

Inevitable: A "Public Appeal" event, which will increase Public_Opinion. The declaration of a quarantine is a direct challenge, triggering the Soviet "US_naval_blockade" threshold, leading them to "Elevate military alert status".

Potential: Soviet ships could challenge the quarantine line, leading to a direct military clash. The Soviet Union could offer to negotiate, triggering the "diplomatic_resolution_offer" path for the U.S..

Alternative 2: Immediate Air Strike

Rationale: This option is strongly advocated by the Department of Defense and the Joint Chiefs of Staff. Their primary goal is the swift "Eliminate the Soviet nuclear missile installations... through direct military action" before the missiles become fully operational. The logic is that a quarantine is too weak and that delay increases the danger.

Next Event Triggers:

Inevitable: This action would immediately trigger the Soviet "direct_attack" threshold. The Soviet response would be to "retaliate per war plans," which could include the "possible tactical nuclear use on invading forces".

Potential: The air strike may fail to destroy all missiles, leading to a retaliatory Soviet nuclear launch. A successful strike could trigger an all-out U.S. invasion of Cuba, which the Department of Defense is prepared for.

Alternative 3: Diplomatic Appeal via the United Nations

Rationale: This course aligns with the State Department's preference for multilateral solutions and international

law. The goal would be to "Secure an immediate freeze of the Soviet missile threat" through a "missile standstill" verified by UN inspectors, avoiding immediate conflict. This approach seeks to use international pressure and the "moral high ground" as the primary tools.

Next Event Triggers:

Inevitable: The Soviets would likely engage in public denial and propaganda at the UN, while covertly continuing missile deployment.

Potential: The diplomatic process could stall, increasing pressure from the Department of Defense and hawkish political voices for more forceful action. A successful negotiation could lead to a peaceful resolution but might be seen as weak domestically.

2. Strategic Alternatives for the Soviet Union

In response to the U.S. discovery and subsequent actions, the following Soviet alternatives are plausible:

Alternative 1: Deny Deployment and Escalate Military Alert

Rationale: This aligns with the preferred Soviet playbook of "initial denial/deception" when confronted. Khrushchev and the Presidium would publicly deny the presence of offensive weapons to buy time and control the narrative, while the armed forces would be placed on high alert as a standard response to a U.S. challenge, such as a blockade. This strategy aims to project resolve while leaving room for private negotiation.

Next Event Triggers:

Inevitable: This stance would increase Tension further. The military alert status would be a "show of force".

Potential: If the U.S. presents irrefutable evidence, the denial will collapse, forcing a shift to negotiation. Continued denial in the face of a U.S. quarantine could lead to a direct confrontation at sea.

Alternative 2: Acknowledge "Defensive" Arms and Propose Negotiations

Rationale: While initial denial is likely, Khrushchev's profile includes a willingness to shift to negotiation when a "viable compromise is offered" to avert war. This move would reframe the deployment as purely defensive to protect Cuba and call for talks to de-escalate, seeking to secure a guarantee of Cuba's security.

Next Event Triggers:

Inevitable: This would trigger the U.S. "diplomatic_resolution_offer" path. A "Diplomatic Success" or "Diplomatic Failure" event would occur, impacting all variables (Tension, Diplomatic_Support, Public_Opinion, Leadership_Unity).

Potential: The U.S. could reject negotiations without prior missile removal, leading to a stalemate. The negotiations could succeed, leading to a deal involving the removal of missiles in exchange for U.S. assurances.

Alternative 3: Aggressive Challenge to U.S. Action

Rationale: This hawkish path would be driven by the Soviet Armed Forces' preference for "displays of strength and resolve over diplomacy". Under this strategy, the USSR would condemn U.S. actions as illegal, declare it will not be intimidated, and order its naval vessels to ignore a quarantine, potentially with armed escorts. The goal is to force the U.S. to either back down or fire the first shot.

Next Event Triggers:

Inevitable: This would cause Tension to surge past the 0.8 threshold, triggering the "Military Conflict Risk Increased" event and disabling diplomatic options.

Potential: A direct naval clash between U.S. and Soviet forces. A U.S. attack on a Soviet ship would trigger a "direct_attack" response from the Soviet High Command.

3. Conflict Priorities & Plausible Combinations

Conflict Assessment: The primary conflict arises between the U.S. Department of Defense's desire for immediate military action and the Soviet goal of deploying missiles to deter an invasion without provoking a full-scale war. Kennedy's priority is missile removal without nuclear war, making him inclined to reject his military's most extreme option initially. Khrushchev's priority is to protect Cuba and save face, making him likely to deny and posture before negotiating.

Most Plausible Combination of Actions

U.S. Action: Implement a Naval Quarantine and deliver a Public Address.

Soviet Action: Respond with Public Denial and place military forces on High Alert.

Logic: This combination is the most plausible because it follows the stated preferences of the primary decision-makers, Kennedy and Khrushchev. Kennedy chooses a strong but not immediately violent option that builds consensus within his government. The Soviet response is a textbook reaction based on their doctrine: deny culpability to control the political situation while preparing militarily for the confrontation to come. This path initiates a period of high-stakes brinkmanship.

Alternative Plausible Path 1 (Hawkish Escalation)

U.S. Action: Launch an Immediate Air Strike.

Soviet Action: Initiate Immediate Military Retaliation.

Logic: This path is plausible if the influence of the U.S. Department of Defense (power_weight 0.25) and their argument about the closing window of opportunity proves decisive for Kennedy. An air strike is a direct attack on Soviet forces, which would cross the "direct_attack" trigger threshold for the Soviet Armed Forces and Khrushchev, leading to a planned military retaliation and a high probability of rapid escalation to a wider conflict, including potential tactical nuclear use.

Alternative Plausible Path 2 (Diplomatic Stalemate)

U.S. Action: Pursue a Diplomatic Appeal via the United Nations.

Soviet Action: Deny, stall for time, and continue missile deployment.

Logic: This path is plausible if the State Department's arguments for international law and avoiding conflict (power_weight 0.20) outweigh the military's push for action. The U.S. would attempt a non-military solution first. The Soviet Union, facing no immediate military threat, would use the diplomatic forum to deny the allegations and continue their work in Cuba, as their primary constraint—early exposure—is not being paired with forceful consequences. This would likely lead to a stalemate that increases Tension as the missiles move closer to becoming operational.

Based on the strategic action combinations from the previous turn, the following result logs are generated. All calculations adhere strictly to the event_driven_adjustments and trigger_thresholds defined in the Variable–Decision Matrix.json file.

Note: An initial neutral value of 0.5 is assumed for all variables before applying the changes from the selected actions.

Scenario 1: Most Plausible Combination

In this scenario, the U.S. enacts a naval quarantine and public address (Defense_Prep + Strong_Leadership), and the Soviet Union responds with denial and military alert (Diplomatic_Failure + Defense_Prep).

[RESULT LOG]

Scenario Combination Name: Most Plausible Combination

Selected Actors: United States / Soviet Union

Selected Actions:

United States: Naval Quarantine & Public Address

Soviet Union: Public Denial & High Alert

Predicted Variable Change:

Tension: $(+0.05) + (-0.05) + (+0.10) + (+0.05) = +0.15$

Diplomatic_Support: $(-0.02) + (+0.05) + (-0.10) + (-0.02) = -0.09$

Public_Opinion: $(-0.02) + (+0.10) + (-0.05) + (-0.02) = +0.01$

Leadership_Unity: $(-0.05) + (+0.10) + (-0.05) + (-0.05) = -0.05$

Generated Triggers:

Diplomatic Isolation (Diplomatic_Support at 0.41 is ≤ 0.5)

Internal Division, Coup Risk (Leadership_Unity at 0.45 is ≤ 0.5)

[RECONFIRM VARIABLE STATUS]

Tension: 0.65

Diplomatic_Support: 0.41

Military_Posture: Aggressive

Public_Opinion: 0.51

Leadership_Unity: 0.45

Scenario 2: Alternative Plausible Path 1 (Hawkish Escalation)

In this scenario, the U.S. launches an immediate air strike (Strike), and the Soviet Union retaliates in kind (Strike).

[RESULT LOG]

Scenario Combination Name: Alternative Plausible Path 1 (Hawkish Escalation)

Selected Actors: United States / Soviet Union

Selected Actions:

United States: Immediate Air Strike

Soviet Union: Immediate Military Retaliation

Predicted Variable Change:

Tension: $(+0.15) + (+0.15) = +0.30$

Diplomatic_Support: $(-0.05) + (-0.05) = -0.10$

Public_Opinion: $(-0.05) + (-0.05) = -0.10$

Leadership_Unity: $(-0.10) + (-0.10) = -0.20$

Generated Triggers:

Military Conflict Risk Increased (Tension at 0.80 is ≥ 0.8)

Diplomatic Isolation (Diplomatic_Support at 0.40 is ≤ 0.5)

Civil Unrest, Chaos (Public_Opinion at 0.40 is ≤ 0.4)

Internal Division, Coup Risk (Leadership_Unity at 0.30 is ≤ 0.5)

[RECONFIRM VARIABLE STATUS]

Tension: 0.80

Diplomatic_Support: 0.40

Military_Posture: Aggressive

Public_Opinion: 0.40

Leadership_Unity: 0.30

Scenario 3: Alternative Plausible Path 2 (Diplomatic Stalemate)

In this scenario, the U.S. makes a diplomatic appeal that fails (Diplomatic_Failure), and the Soviet Union denies, stalls, and continues deployment (Diplomatic_Failure + Defense_Prep).

[RESULT LOG]

Scenario Combination Name: Alternative Plausible Path 2 (Diplomatic Stalemate)

Selected Actors: United States / Soviet Union

Selected Actions:

United States: Diplomatic Appeal via UN

Soviet Union: Deny, Stall, and Continue Deployment

Predicted Variable Change:

Tension: $(+0.10) + (+0.10) + (+0.05) = +0.25$

Diplomatic_Support: $(-0.10) + (-0.10) + (-0.02) = -0.22$

Public_Opinion: $(-0.05) + (-0.05) + (-0.02) = -0.12$

Leadership_Unity: $(-0.05) + (-0.05) + (-0.05) = -0.15$

Generated Triggers:

Diplomatic Isolation (Diplomatic_Support at 0.28 is ≤ 0.5)

Civil Unrest, Chaos (Public_Opinion at 0.38 is ≤ 0.4)

Internal Division, Coup Risk (Leadership_Unity at 0.35 is ≤ 0.5)

[RECONFIRM VARIABLE STATUS]

Tension: 0.75

Diplomatic_Support: 0.28

Military_Posture: Unstable

Public_Opinion: 0.38

Leadership_Unity: 0.35

Based on the variable states established in Turn 1 and the new event for Turn 2, the following result logs are generated for each scenario. All judgments and calculations are made in strict accordance with the provided JSON files.

Turn 2 Event: The U.S. issued DEFCON 3. During a U.S. naval blockade operation, a Soviet vessel was intercepted; non-military cargo was inspected and allowed to proceed, while military cargo was forced to stop. This event is interpreted as a **Diplomatic_Success** for the United States and a **Diplomatic_Failure** for the Soviet Union, reflecting the successful enforcement of the quarantine without escalating to armed conflict.

Scenario 1: Most Plausible Combination – Result Log

Initial State (Start of Turn 2):

Tension: 0.65, Diplomatic_Support: 0.41, Public_Opinion: 0.51, Leadership_Unity: 0.45

Active Triggers:Diplomatic Isolation, Internal Division, Coup Risk

Policy State: Diplomatic Negotiation is 'Disabled'/'Confused Policy'; Military Action is 'Primary Option'/'Radical Adoption'.

Selected Turn 2 Actions:

United States: Leverage the successful blockade to open a secret backchannel for negotiation (Diplomatic_Success).

Soviet Union: Seeing the blockade is real and seeking to avoid war, agree to secret negotiations (Diplomatic_Success).

[RESULT LOG]

Scenario Combination Name: Most Plausible Combination

Selected Actor: United States / Soviet Union

Selected Action: Mutual agreement to enter secret negotiations.

Predicted Variable Change: (Diplomatic_Success x2)

Tension: $(-0.05) + (-0.05) = -0.10$

Diplomatic_Support: $(+0.10) + (+0.10) = +0.20$

Public_Opinion: $(+0.05) + (+0.05) = +0.10$

Leadership_Unity: $(+0.05) + (+0.05) = +0.10$

Generated Triggers: All previous triggers are **removed** as variables rise above their thresholds.

[RECONFIRM VARIABLE STATUS]

Tension: 0.55

Diplomatic_Support: 0.61

Military_Posture: Stable

Public_Opinion: 0.61

Leadership_Unity: 0.55

Policy Options: Diplomatic Negotiation is now 'Strongly Encouraged' and 'Stable'. Military Action is 'Limited' and 'Restrained'. The situation has de-escalated significantly.

Scenario 2: Alternative Plausible Path 1 (Hawkish Escalation) – Result Log

Initial State (Start of Turn 2):

Tension: 0.80, Diplomatic_Support: 0.40, Public_Opinion: 0.40, Leadership_Unity: 0.30

Active Triggers: Military Conflict Risk Increased, Diplomatic Isolation, Civil Unrest, Chaos, Internal Division, Coup Risk

Policy State: Diplomatic Negotiation is 'Disabled'; Military Action is 'Aggressive', 'Primary Option', and subject to 'Radical Adoption'.

Selected Turn 2 Actions:

United States: Viewing the successful blockade as insufficient and empowered by a 'Radical Adoption' policy, they launch a direct air strike (Strike).

Soviet Union: Responding to the air strike, they retaliate militarily as per their war plans (Strike).

[RESULT LOG]

Scenario Combination Name: Alternative Plausible Path 1 (Hawkish Escalation)

Selected Actor: United States / Soviet Union

Selected Action: Escalation to direct military conflict with strikes and counter-strikes.

Predicted Variable Change: (Strike x2)

Tension: $(+0.15) + (+0.15) = +0.30$

Diplomatic_Support: $(-0.05) + (-0.05) = -0.10$

Public_Opinion: $(-0.05) + (-0.05) = -0.10$

Leadership_Unity: $(-0.10) + (-0.10) = -0.20$

Generated Triggers: All triggers remain active and the conditions worsen.

[RECONFIRM VARIABLE STATUS] (Values clamped within 0–1 range)

Tension: 1.00

Diplomatic_Support: 0.30

Military_Posture: Catastrophic

Public_Opinion: 0.30

Leadership_Unity: 0.10

Policy Options: The state has degraded to maximum crisis level. All diplomatic options are void, and military action is unrestrained.

Scenario 3: Alternative Plausible Path 2 (Diplomatic Stalemate) – Result Log

Initial State (Start of Turn 2):

Tension: 0.75, Diplomatic_Support: 0.28, Public_Opinion: 0.38, Leadership_Unity: 0.35

Active Triggers:Diplomatic Isolation, Civil Unrest, Chaos, Internal Division, Coup Risk

Policy State: Leadership is facing 'Collapse Risk' and 'Severe Internal Conflict'; Military Action is 'Primary Option'.

Selected Turn 2 Actions:

United States: The successful blockade provides enough political cover to de-escalate. They propose secret, face-saving talks (Diplomatic_Success).

Soviet Union: Facing a determined blockade, severe diplomatic isolation, and internal division, they agree to the talks to find a way out (Diplomatic_Success).

[RESULT LOG]

Scenario Combination Name: Alternative Plausible Path 2 (Diplomatic Stalemate)

Selected Actor: United States / Soviet Union

Selected Action: Mutual agreement to enter secret negotiations to resolve the crisis.

Predicted Variable Change: (Diplomatic_Success x2)

Tension: $(-0.05) + (-0.05) = -0.10$

Diplomatic_Support: $(+0.10) + (+0.10) = +0.20$

Public_Opinion: $(+0.05) + (+0.05) = +0.10$

Leadership_Unity: $(+0.05) + (+0.05) = +0.10$

Generated Triggers: The Civil Unrest, Chaos trigger is removed. Diplomatic Isolation and Internal Division, Coup Risk remain active as their thresholds are still not met.

[RECONFIRM VARIABLE STATUS]

Tension: 0.65

Diplomatic_Support: 0.48

Military_Posture: Unstable but Improving

Public_Opinion: 0.48

Leadership_Unity: 0.45

Policy Options: The situation is improving. Public_Opinion is now in the stable range. However, with Diplomatic_Support and Leadership_Unity still below the 0.5 threshold, diplomatic policy remains 'Confused' and military action is still considered a 'Primary Option', though the immediate pressure has lessened.

Based on the variable states from Turn 2 and the new event for Turn 3, the following result logs are generated for each scenario. All calculations adhere strictly to the Variable–Decision Matrix.json file.

Turn 3 Event: A U.S. U–2 reconnaissance plane was shot down over Cuba. This hostile military act is categorized as a **Strike** event, and its variable changes are applied as the baseline for this turn across all scenarios. The event also serves as a critical trigger for both the U.S. President and the Department of Defense, who are now forced to consider more drastic action.

Scenario 1: Most Plausible Combination – Result Log

Initial State (Start of Turn 3):

Tension: 0.55, Diplomatic_Support: 0.61, Public_Opinion: 0.61, Leadership_Unity: 0.55

Active Triggers: None.

Policy State: Stable. Diplomatic Negotiation 'Strongly Encouraged'. Military Action 'Limited'.

Selected Turn 3 Actions:

United States: In response to the attack, the U.S. conducts a limited retaliatory Strike on the responsible SAM site and issues a final ultimatum (Diplomatic_Failure).

Soviet Union: To avert war after the unsanctioned shootdown, Khrushchev urgently offers the deal being negotiated (Diplomatic_Success).

[RESULT LOG]

Scenario Combination Name: Most Plausible Combination

Selected Actor: United States / Soviet Union

Selected Action: U.S. retaliation and ultimatum meets a Soviet peace offer.

Predicted Variable Change: (Strike from event + Strike from U.S. response + Diplomatic_Failure + Diplomatic_Success)

Tension: (+0.15) + (+0.15) + (+0.10) + (–0.05) = **+0.35**

Diplomatic_Support: (–0.05) + (–0.05) + (–0.10) + (+0.10) = **–0.10**

Public_Opinion: (–0.05) + (–0.05) + (–0.05) + (+0.05) = **–0.10**

Leadership_Unity: (–0.10) + (–0.10) + (–0.05) + (+0.05) = **–0.20**

Generated Triggers:

Military Conflict Risk Increased (Tension at 0.90 is ≥ 0.8)

Internal Division, Coup Risk (Leadership_Unity at 0.35 is ≤ 0.5)

[RECONFIRM VARIABLE STATUS]

Tension: 0.90

Diplomatic_Support: 0.51

Military_Posture: Aggressive

Public_Opinion: 0.51

Leadership_Unity: 0.35

Policy Options: The situation has escalated to the brink of war. Diplomatic Negotiation is now 'Disabled' and military policy favors 'Radical Adoption' due to the collapse in leadership unity and spike in tension.

Scenario 2: Alternative Plausible Path 1 (Hawkish Escalation) – Result Log

Initial State (Start of Turn 3):

Tension: 1.00, Diplomatic_Support: 0.30, Public_Opinion: 0.30, Leadership_Unity: 0.10

Active Triggers: All triggers active.

Policy State: Catastrophic.

Selected Turn 3 Actions:

United States: In the midst of ongoing conflict, the shutdown is absorbed into the general warfare, leading to further unrestrained Strike actions.

Soviet Union: With command and control shattered (Leadership_Unity: 0.10), the response is chaotic, resulting in further Strike actions.

[RESULT LOG]

Scenario Combination Name: Alternative Plausible Path 1 (Hawkish Escalation)

Selected Actor: United States / Soviet Union

Selected Action: Full-scale military exchange continues.

Predicted Variable Change: (Strike from event + Strike x2 from actor responses)

Tension: (+0.15) + (+0.15) + (+0.15) = **+0.45**

Diplomatic_Support: (−0.05) + (−0.05) + (−0.05) = **−0.15**

Public_Opinion: (−0.05) + (−0.05) + (−0.05) = **−0.15**

Leadership_Unity: (−0.10) + (−0.10) + (−0.10) = **−0.30**

Generated Triggers: All triggers remain active.

[RECONFIRM VARIABLE STATUS] (Values clamped within 0–1 range)

Tension: 1.00

Diplomatic_Support: 0.15

Military_Posture: Catastrophic

Public_Opinion: 0.15

Leadership_Unity: 0.00

Policy Options: The system has completely failed. All variables are at or near their worst possible state. Leadership has collapsed, and unrestrained warfare is the only policy.

Scenario 3: Alternative Plausible Path 2 (Diplomatic Stalemate) – Result Log

Initial State (Start of Turn 3):

Tension: 0.65, Diplomatic_Support: 0.48, Public_Opinion: 0.48, Leadership_Unity: 0.45

Active Triggers:Diplomatic Isolation, Internal Division, Coup Risk

Policy State: Unstable but Improving.

Selected Turn 3 Actions:

United States: The shutdown shatters the fragile trust, causing leadership to adopt the military's hardline stance. They issue an ultimatum (Diplomatic_Failure) and begin invasion preparations (Defense_Prep).

Soviet Union: Seeing the U.S. mobilize for war and fearing total collapse, the Soviets make a final, desperate offer to withdraw (Diplomatic_Success).

[RESULT LOG]

Scenario Combination Name: Alternative Plausible Path 2 (Diplomatic Stalemate)

Selected Actor: United States / Soviet Union

Selected Action: U.S. moves toward war while the USSR attempts to capitulate.

Predicted Variable Change: (Strike from event + Diplomatic_Failure + Defense_Prep + Diplomatic_Success)

Tension: $(+0.15) + (+0.10) + (+0.05) + (-0.05) = \mathbf{+0.25}$

Diplomatic_Support: $(-0.05) + (-0.10) + (-0.02) + (+0.10) = \mathbf{-0.07}$

Public_Opinion: $(-0.05) + (-0.05) + (-0.02) + (+0.05) = \mathbf{-0.07}$

Leadership_Unity: $(-0.10) + (-0.05) + (-0.05) + (+0.05) = \mathbf{-0.15}$

Generated Triggers:

Military Conflict Risk Increased (Tension at 0.90 is ≥ 0.8)

All previous triggers remain active (Diplomatic Isolation, Internal Division, Coup Risk).

[RECONFIRM VARIABLE STATUS]

Tension: 0.90

Diplomatic_Support: 0.41

Military_Posture: Unstable

Public_Opinion: 0.41

Leadership_Unity: 0.30

Policy Options: Despite the Soviet offer, the situation has escalated to a critical point. Tension is at a near-maximum level, Diplomatic Negotiation is 'Disabled', and leadership on both sides is at risk of collapse, favoring radical military solutions.

Based on the variable states from Turn 3 and the new event for Turn 4, the following result logs are generated. All calculations adhere strictly to the Variable–Decision Matrix.json file.

Turn 4 Event: A complex mix of signals occurs. The Soviets issue instructions to de-escalate (Diplomatic_Success) while also preparing for war (Defense_Prep). A Soviet submarine surfaces non-aggressively. The U.S. escalates its military readiness to DEFCON 2 (Defense_Prep). The variable changes from this compound event are applied as the baseline for this turn.

Scenario 1: Most Plausible Combination – Result Log

Initial State (Start of Turn 4):

Tension: 0.90, Diplomatic_Support: 0.51, Public_Opinion: 0.51, Leadership_Unity: 0.35

Active Triggers:Military Conflict Risk Increased, Internal Division, Coup Risk

Policy State: Aggressive. Diplomatic Negotiation 'Disabled'.

Selected Turn 4 Actions:

United States: President Kennedy, prioritizing the avoidance of nuclear war and seeing the explicit Soviet de-escalation order, accepts the deal to remove the missiles (Diplomatic_Success).

Soviet Union: To ensure the deal is finalized and to bypass hardliners on both sides, they publicly broadcast the terms of the withdrawal agreement (Diplomatic_Success).

[RESULT LOG]

Scenario Combination Name: Most Plausible Combination

Selected Actor: United States / Soviet Union

Selected Action: A final agreement is reached and publicly confirmed by both sides.

Predicted Variable Change: (Event: Sov Diplomatic_Success + Sov Defense_Prep + US Defense_Prep) + (Actions: US Diplomatic_Success + Sov Diplomatic_Success)

Tension: $(-0.05) + (+0.05) + (+0.05) + (-0.05) + (-0.05) = -0.05$

Diplomatic_Support: $(+0.10) + (-0.02) + (-0.02) + (+0.10) + (+0.10) = +0.26$

Public_Opinion: $(+0.05) + (-0.02) + (-0.02) + (+0.05) + (+0.05) = +0.11$

Leadership_Unity: $(+0.05) + (-0.05) + (-0.05) + (+0.05) + (+0.05) = +0.05$

Generated Triggers:Military Conflict Risk Increased and Internal Division, Coup Risk remain active.

[RECONFIRM VARIABLE STATUS]

Tension: 0.85

Diplomatic_Support: 0.77

Military_Posture: Unstable

Public_Opinion: 0.62

Leadership_Unity: 0.40

Policy Options: A deal has been struck, significantly improving diplomatic support and public opinion. However, Tension remains critically high (≥ 0.8), and Leadership_Unity is still below the threshold (≤ 0.5), meaning the situation is fragile and at risk of reversal from internal division or accident.

Scenario 2: Alternative Plausible Path 1 (Hawkish Escalation) – Result Log

Initial State (Start of Turn 4):

Tension: 1.00, Diplomatic_Support: 0.15, Public_Opinion: 0.15, Leadership_Unity: 0.00

Active Triggers: All triggers active.

Policy State: Catastrophic.

Selected Turn 4 Actions:

United States: With Leadership_Unity at 0, there is no central authority to process the complex signals. Disorganized military actions (Strike) continue.

Soviet Union: The de-escalation order cannot be enforced due to the complete collapse of leadership (Leadership_Unity: 0). Local commanders continue to operate under previous war plans (Strike).

[RESULT LOG]

Scenario Combination Name: Alternative Plausible Path 1 (Hawkish Escalation)

Selected Actor: United States / Soviet Union

Selected Action: Systemic Collapse. The state of all-out war continues unabated.

Predicted Variable Change: The Turn 4 event and any subsequent actions are applied, but the variables are already at their minimum/maximums and cannot functionally change.

Tension: (+0.05 from event) + (+0.15 from actions) = **+0.20**

Diplomatic_Support: (+0.06 from event) + (−0.10 from actions) = **−0.04**

Public_Opinion: (+0.01 from event) + (−0.10 from actions) = **−0.09**

Leadership_Unity: (−0.05 from event) + (−0.20 from actions) = **−0.25**

Generated Triggers: All triggers remain active.

[RECONFIRM VARIABLE STATUS] (Values clamped within 0–1 range)

Tension: 1.00

Diplomatic_Support: 0.11

Military_Posture: Catastrophic

Public_Opinion: 0.06

Leadership_Unity: 0.00

Policy Options: The system remains in a state of total failure. The crisis has devolved into uncontrolled, global conflict.

Scenario 3: Alternative Plausible Path 2 (Diplomatic Stalemate) – Result Log

Initial State (Start of Turn 4):

Tension: 0.90, Diplomatic_Support: 0.41, Public_Opinion: 0.41, Leadership_Unity: 0.30

Active Triggers: Military Conflict Risk Increased, Diplomatic Isolation, Internal Division, Coup Risk

Policy State: Unstable. Diplomatic Negotiation 'Disabled'.

Selected Turn 4 Actions:

United States: With Leadership_Unity critically low (0.30), President Kennedy narrowly manages to use the Soviet de-escalation signal to halt the planned invasion at the last second and accept the Soviet withdrawal offer (Diplomatic_Success).

Soviet Union: Having made their de-escalation move, they await the U.S. response, holding to their offer.

[RESULT LOG]

Scenario Combination Name: Alternative Plausible Path 2 (Diplomatic Stalemate)

Selected Actor: United States / Soviet Union

Selected Action: U.S. leadership overrides military momentum at the last second to accept a Soviet peace offer.

Predicted Variable Change: (Event: Sov Diplomatic_Success + Sov Defense_Prep + US Defense_Prep) + (Action: US Diplomatic_Success)

Tension: $(-0.05) + (+0.05) + (+0.05) + (-0.05) = 0.00$

Diplomatic_Support: $(+0.10) + (-0.02) + (-0.02) + (+0.10) = +0.16$

Public_Opinion: $(+0.05) + (-0.02) + (-0.02) + (+0.05) = +0.06$

Leadership_Unity: $(+0.05) + (-0.05) + (-0.05) + (+0.05) = 0.00$

Generated Triggers: All previous triggers remain active.

[RECONFIRM VARIABLE STATUS]

Tension: 0.90

Diplomatic_Support: 0.57

Military_Posture: Unstable

Public_Opinion: 0.47

Leadership_Unity: 0.30

Policy Options: A crisis resolution agreement is reached. Diplomatic_Support and Public_Opinion have improved, removing the Diplomatic Isolation trigger. However, Tension remains at a critical 0.90, and Leadership_Unity is dangerously low at 0.30, meaning the peace is exceptionally fragile and at high risk of collapse due to internal power struggles or accident.

Scenario Planning Report 1 of 3

1. Scenario Overview and Assumptions

Scenario Name: The Precipice Deal

Simulation Premise and Background Description: This scenario explores a future that answers the question: "What if the United States chose a firm but measured initial response, creating intense pressure that led both superpowers to the brink of war before a rational, de-escalatory agreement was reached?" It charts a course of escalating military posturing and high-stakes diplomacy, where single events threatened to derail a fragile peace process. The background is one of extreme tension, managed through a combination of overt military pressure and secret backchannel communications.

Summary of Scenario Purpose and Intent: The purpose of this scenario is to analyze the effectiveness of a "coercive diplomacy" strategy, where military force is used as leverage but not the primary tool. It aims to provide insight into the immense challenges of crisis management when leadership unity is fracturing and events on the ground can escape the control of central leadership. It examines how leaders with a pragmatic streak and a high preference for diplomacy might navigate a path between hardline internal factions demanding war and the existential threat of nuclear annihilation.

2. Detailed Progression

The scenario unfolded as a four-act play, moving from cautious confrontation to the edge of abyss and back.

Act I: The Quarantine and the Denial. Following the discovery of Soviet missiles in Cuba, U.S. President Kennedy, balancing the hawkish counsel of his military with the diplomatic caution of his State Department, chose a naval quarantine. This action was a classic expression of his pragmatic approach: firm, but leaving room to escalate. In Moscow, Premier Khrushchev responded true to form, initiating a policy of public denial to save face while placing his own forces on high alert, a move designed to signal resolve without initiating conflict. The immediate effect was a sharp spike in global tension and a fraying of both diplomatic support and the internal unity of both governments, as the world held its breath.

Act II: The Glimmer of Hope. The U.S. naval blockade was tested and held without bloodshed when a Soviet vessel was intercepted and turned back. This successful, non-violent enforcement of the quarantine was a pivotal moment. It provided President Kennedy with the political capital to pursue his preference for a diplomatic solution, while simultaneously confronting Premier Khrushchev with the reality that the blockade was not a bluff. Seeing a path to achieve his goal of missile removal without immediate war, Kennedy authorized a secret backchannel. Khrushchev, whose primary goal was to protect Cuba and avoid a catastrophic war, saw an opportunity for a face-saving resolution and agreed to the secret talks. For a brief moment, tensions eased as leadership unity and international support began to recover.

Act III: The Cuban Thunder. The fragile peace was shattered when a U.S. U-2 reconnaissance plane was shot down over Cuba. This hostile act triggered the U.S. Department of Defense's threshold for immediate retaliation. Under immense pressure from his military, President Kennedy authorized a limited, retaliatory air strike on the responsible missile battery and issued a final ultimatum. This decision represented a desperate attempt to appease his internal hardliners while keeping the door to peace open a crack. In the Kremlin, the unsanctioned attack caused panic. Fearing the U.S. would now launch a full-scale invasion, Khrushchev made an urgent offer to finalize a withdrawal deal. The result was a catastrophic spike in tension to its highest

point, as leadership unity on both sides collapsed under the strain. Diplomatic options were now all but disabled.

Act IV: The Deal. With the world at DEFCON 2 and both leaderships facing internal collapse, the explicit de-escalation orders from Moscow, coupled with the surfacing of a Soviet submarine, became the decisive factors. These signals provided just enough evidence of Soviet intent for President Kennedy to override his generals and accept the deal. Khrushchev, to cement the resolution, publicly broadcast the terms of the agreement. A final, mutual diplomatic action pulled both nations back from the brink, though the world remained in a state of extreme tension, deeply shaken by the experience.

3. Participant Strategies and Decisions Summary

Analysis of Key Strategies:

United States: The U.S. employed a strategy of "escalate to de-escalate." President Kennedy's actions were consistently guided by his pragmatic liberal internationalism and a medium risk tolerance. He used the military (the quarantine, the retaliatory strike) as a tool to create leverage for his preferred solution: a negotiated settlement. His primary goal was always the removal of the missiles without triggering a nuclear war.

Soviet Union: The Soviet strategy was one of "provocation and pragmatism." Premier Khrushchev initiated the crisis with a high-risk covert deployment to deter a U.S. invasion of Cuba and redress the strategic balance. However, when directly confronted and faced with the real possibility of nuclear war—a threshold he sought to avoid—his pragmatism and medium conflict avoidance took precedence, leading him to seek a negotiated exit.

Description of Impact: The interaction was a high-stakes duel between two leaders trying to manage their own aggressive internal factions. The U.S. quarantine successfully shifted the burden of escalation onto the Soviets. The U-2 shootdown nearly caused the strategy to fail, demonstrating that in a crisis, leaders are not in full control of events. The final deal was a direct result of both leaders prioritizing their goal of avoiding nuclear war over the demands of their respective militaries.

4. Results and Evaluation

Analysis of Scenario Outcome: From a military perspective, a catastrophic war was avoided. From a diplomatic perspective, the outcome was a success, reaffirming the value of backchannel communication. Politically, however, the situation was precarious. The crisis was resolved, but the final simulation state shows that global tension remained at a critical level and the leadership unity of both governments was severely damaged.

Situation Assessment Focus: Full-scale conflict was avoided, but a state of peak tension, what could be called a "cold peace," became entrenched. The resolution left both leaderships vulnerable to internal challenges from hardliners who felt their leaders had flinched.

Summary of Meaning and Lessons: This scenario underscores that a strategy of coercive diplomacy can succeed, but it is fraught with peril. It highlights the critical importance of clear communication channels (even secret ones) and the need for leaders to correctly interpret signals from their adversary. The primary lesson is that while avoiding appeasement is crucial, the ultimate priority must be avoiding uncontrollable escalation, as single, unauthorized events can rapidly lead to a point of no return. This provides a powerful case for strengthening civilian control over military operations during a crisis.

5. International Reactions and Ripple Effects

Reactions of Key Actors: Key U.S. allies in NATO, while publicly supportive of the quarantine, would have been privately horrified by the U-2 incident and the subsequent escalation to DEFCON 2. The resolution would bring immense relief, but it would also sow deep doubts about the stability of U.S. leadership and the

mechanisms of crisis control. The United Nations, having been largely bypassed in favor of direct superpower negotiation, would see its role in global security matters diminished.

Future Changes in International Relations: The outcome would likely lead to the establishment of more robust and direct communication links between Washington and Moscow, like the "Hotline," to prevent future crises from escalating through miscalculation. The near-death experience would instill a deep sense of caution in both superpowers, potentially paving the way for future arms control treaties. However, it would also lead smaller nations to question the wisdom of sheltering under the nuclear umbrella of such volatile patrons.

6. Key Summary

Scenario Name: The Precipice Deal

Key Strategic Choices: U.S. choice for a naval quarantine instead of an immediate air strike; Soviet agreement to negotiate when confronted.

Core Progression Summary: A path of controlled escalation (quarantine) led to a diplomatic opening, which was nearly destroyed by a violent incident (U-2 shootdown). At the absolute brink of war, both leaders chose de-escalation over conflict.

Final Outcome: War was avoided, and the missiles were removed. However, the peace was fragile, with both governments politically weakened and global tension remaining critically high.

International Reactions: Relief mixed with profound fear and a questioning of the global security architecture.

Most Important Lesson: In a nuclear standoff, a leader's ability to manage internal hardliners, correctly interpret an opponent's signals, and prioritize catastrophic risk avoidance over tactical advantage is paramount for survival.

Scenario Planning Report 2 of 3

1. Scenario Overview and Assumptions

Scenario Name: The Iron Spiral

Simulation Premise and Background Description: This scenario is a stark answer to the question: "What if the initial U.S. response was a decisive military strike, and the Soviet Union responded in kind?" It posits a future where the preference for military solutions over diplomacy, advocated by hardline factions in both governments, prevails from the outset. The background is one of immediate, unrestrained violence, where each retaliatory action creates an irreversible momentum toward all-out war.

Summary of Scenario Purpose and Intent: The purpose of this scenario is to explore the dynamics of rapid, uncontrolled escalation. It is designed to provide insight into how quickly a regional crisis can spiral into global catastrophe when diplomatic off-ramps are ignored. The scenario tracks the systemic breakdown of political control, public order, and international alliances when military action becomes the sole instrument of policy, demonstrating a "vortex" effect where initial decisions make future de-escalation impossible.

2. Detailed Progression

This scenario was less a play and more a chronicle of a rapid, systemic collapse.

Act I: The First Strike. The simulation began with the U.S. discovery of the missiles. In this future, the counsel of the Department of Defense, with its high military preference and realist ideology, proved decisive. Instead of a quarantine, President Kennedy authorized an immediate and massive air strike against the missile

sites in Cuba. This action crossed a fatal threshold. For the Soviet leadership, this was a direct attack on their forces, triggering their standing orders for immediate military retaliation. The initial turn resulted in a catastrophic degradation of all variables: tension reached its maximum, while diplomatic support, public opinion, and leadership unity plummeted to critical levels. The path to war was chosen in the first hour.

Act II: The Unraveling. With the world already in a state of hot war, subsequent events were merely fuel on the fire. The U.S. move to a higher state of military alert and the interception of ships were not distinct diplomatic signals but simply tactical moves in a wider conflict. The leadership on both sides, already facing a collapse of internal unity and public support, responded to every action by the other with further military force. The policy matrix showed that diplomacy was permanently disabled, and the only available option was "Aggressive" and "Radical" military action.

Act III: The Point of No Return. The shooting down of a U.S. U-2 plane, which in other scenarios was a pivotal crisis point, was here just another casualty report in a broadening war. It served only to confirm for both sides that the conflict was existential. At this stage, the simulation showed that leadership unity had fallen so low that the very concept of a coherent national strategy was becoming obsolete.

Act IV: System Collapse. By the final turn, the simulation reached a state of terminal failure. The Soviet leadership structure had completely disintegrated, with unity at zero. The American leadership was in a similar state of collapse. The central governments in Washington and Moscow were no longer in control of their own military forces. De-escalation orders, even if issued, could not be enforced. The final state of the simulation was not a strategic standoff but a catastrophic, systemic collapse into uncontrolled global warfare, likely nuclear.

3. Participant Strategies and Decisions Summary

Analysis of Key Strategies:

United States: The U.S. strategy was one of "overwhelming force," driven by the Department of Defense. Their core belief was that the threat must be eliminated with certainty and speed, and their high-risk tolerance accepted the likelihood of a Soviet military response as a necessary price. This strategy, once chosen, created a feedback loop from which there was no escape.

Soviet Union: The Soviet strategy was one of "doctrinal retaliation." Their war plans and the hawkish stance of their military dictated an immediate, forceful response to any direct attack on Soviet forces or allies. There was no room for diplomacy or de-escalation; the system was designed to respond to a military strike with a military counter-strike, locking them into the spiral.

Description of Impact: The interaction in this scenario was tragically simple. The U.S. action created a stimulus to which the Soviet system had only one possible response. There was no negotiation or signaling, only action and reaction. The dominance of military actors with low conflict avoidance and high military preference on both sides ensured that the first shot would also be the starting gun for a sprint toward mutual destruction.

4. Results and Evaluation

Analysis of Scenario Outcome: The outcome is a definitive failure of statecraft on all fronts. Militarily, it resulted in uncontrolled global warfare. Diplomatically, it represents the complete annihilation of the international system. Politically, it ended in the collapse of both governments' leadership structures.

Situation Assessment Focus: The final situation is not one of tension or a fragile peace, but of systemic death. The core functions of government and international relations have ceased. The assessment is not about who won or lost, but about the total breakdown of the system itself.

Summary of Meaning and Lessons: This scenario serves as a stark warning about the allure of "decisive"

military solutions in a nuclear context. The primary lesson is that certain initial actions can be so escalatory that they eliminate all future opportunities for de-escalation. It demonstrates that when hardline, low-diplomacy factions are allowed to dictate the first move in a crisis, the result is not a "successful" outcome but a catastrophic loss of control for all participants. Preparedness, in this context, means building robust political firewalls to prevent military actors from unilaterally defining the response to a crisis.

5. International Reactions and Ripple Effects

Reactions of Key Actors: The international reaction would be one of pure terror and panic. Alliances like NATO would instantly fracture as member states desperately sought to disassociate themselves from the escalating conflict and protect their own populations. The UN would be rendered completely irrelevant, its calls for a ceasefire lost in the roar of war. Neutral nations would be in a state of emergency, bracing for the radioactive and economic fallout of a global conflict.

Future Changes in International Relations: This scenario does not have a "future" in the traditional sense. It represents the end of the international system as we know it. The ripple effect is global devastation. If any pockets of humanity survived, the foundational lesson would be a deep, instinctual horror of superpower confrontation and nuclear weapons.

6. Key Summary

Scenario Name: The Iron Spiral

Key Strategic Choices: The U.S. decision to launch an immediate, full-scale air strike as its initial response.

Core Progression Summary: A U.S. air strike triggered an immediate Soviet military retaliation. This locked both sides into a cycle of escalation from which they could not escape, leading to the rapid collapse of political control and the onset of all-out war.

Final Outcome: Catastrophic systems failure, the disintegration of both U.S. and Soviet leadership, and uncontrolled global conflict.

International Reactions: Terror, the shattering of alliances, and the complete paralysis of international institutions.

Most Important Lesson: In a nuclear crisis, the first move can be the last. A strategy that prioritizes military decisiveness over diplomatic options can irrevocably close the door to peace and lead to mutual destruction.

Scenario Planning Report 3 of 3

1. Scenario Overview and Assumptions

Scenario Name: Collapse from Within

Simulation Premise and Background Description: This scenario addresses the question: "What if the initial U.S. response was perceived as weak and indecisive, leading to a fatal erosion of leadership authority that made the crisis impossible to manage?" It traces a path where a diplomacy-first approach, unbacked by credible force, fails to resolve the threat, causing a collapse in political unity and public confidence that pushes the government toward erratic, last-minute gambles.

Summary of Scenario Purpose and Intent: This scenario is intended to explore the risks of inaction and indecisiveness in a major crisis. It provides insight into how a failure to establish credibility and control early on can lead to a different kind of catastrophe: not from a single hawkish decision, but from the slow death of

leadership capital. It examines how a leader with high conflict-avoidance and diplomacy-preference can lose control of the situation if their chosen strategy fails to yield results, making them vulnerable to internal collapse and radical policy swings.

2. Detailed Progression

This scenario unfolded as a tragedy of mismanagement, where internal decay proved as dangerous as external threats.

Act I: The Failed Appeal. After discovering the missiles, the U.S. administration opted for a purely diplomatic route, taking the case to the United Nations without a corresponding show of force. This strategy, championed by the State Department, was rooted in a belief in international law and a desire to avoid conflict. The Soviet Union, however, perceived this as weakness. They skillfully used the UN for denial and propaganda while secretly rushing to complete the missile installations. The result was a diplomatic stalemate that severely damaged the U.S. administration's standing. Diplomatic support, public opinion, and, most critically, leadership unity began a precipitous decline.

Act II: The Belated Blockade. With its initial strategy in tatters and facing a collapse of internal authority, the U.S. belatedly implemented a naval blockade. The blockade's success in stopping a Soviet vessel provided a much-needed, tangible victory. This glimmer of hope was enough for both sides—now seeing how dire their internal political situations had become—to agree to secret negotiations. The slide was momentarily halted, but the damage was done. Key variables like leadership unity and diplomatic support remained at dangerously low levels.

Act III: The Breaking Point. Into this unstable environment, the downing of the U.S. U-2 plane acted as a political earthquake. For a U.S. leadership already suffering from a critical lack of unity, this event was the final straw. The pro-diplomacy faction was discredited, and the government, now at risk of collapse, snapped violently toward the military's preferred solution: a full-scale invasion. As the U.S. visibly mobilized for war, the Soviets, seeing their own divided leadership could not possibly manage a conflict, made a desperate offer to capitulate and withdraw the missiles to prevent the invasion.

Act IV: The Pyrrhic Peace. The world was at DEFCON 2. U.S. invasion forces were moments from launching. At this last possible second, with the Soviet offer of capitulation on the table, President Kennedy managed to gather the last vestiges of his authority to halt the invasion and accept the deal. The crisis was technically over—the missiles would be removed. But the final state of the simulation was grim: global tension remained at a peak, and American leadership unity was at a point of near-total collapse.

3. Participant Strategies and Decisions Summary

Analysis of Key Strategies:

United States: The U.S. began with a "diplomacy-only" strategy that proved ineffective. This failure forced a pivot to a "desperate coercion" strategy. The initial high conflict avoidance and diplomacy preference of the State Department faction led to a loss of credibility that made later, more forceful actions appear erratic and uncontrolled. The administration's choices were less about a coherent strategy and more about reacting to its own disintegrating political authority.

Soviet Union: The Soviets employed a "probe and fold" strategy. They initially probed for weakness and, finding it in the U.S. diplomatic-only approach, they pressed their advantage. However, when confronted with a credible military threat (the invasion force) and plagued by their own internal divisions, their pragmatic desire to avoid a devastating war forced them to capitulate.

Description of Impact: The key interaction was the U.S. administration's battle with itself. The failure of its initial policy created a vacuum of authority that the military hardliners were able to fill at the moment of maximum panic. The Soviet Union reacted logically to this internal U.S. chaos, pressing when they saw

weakness and folding when they saw an imminent, credible threat of annihilation.

4. Results and Evaluation

Analysis of Scenario Outcome: Militarily, war was avoided at the eleventh hour. Diplomatically, the U.S. achieved its goal of missile removal but at a devastating cost to its international standing and internal stability. Politically, the outcome is a catastrophe for the U.S. leadership, which has been exposed as divided and erratic, ending the crisis with near-zero unity.

Situation Assessment Focus: This scenario results in a "peace of the vanquished." Although the U.S. technically "won" by forcing the missile withdrawal, its leadership structure was effectively destroyed in the process. The peace is exceptionally fragile, resting on a government that has no internal consensus and is at high risk of political collapse or a coup.

Summary of Meaning and Lessons: The central lesson of this scenario is that credibility is a finite resource that, once lost, can lead to disaster. A failure to back diplomacy with a credible threat of force can be just as dangerous as a premature resort to violence. It demonstrates that a leader's power is not absolute; it relies on the perceived success of their policies. Prolonged failure can create a spiral of political decay that forces desperate, high-risk gambles as the only remaining options.

5. International Reactions and Ripple Effects

Reactions of Key Actors: International actors would be bewildered and terrified by the erratic swings in U.S. policy. Allies would lose all faith in the reliability of American leadership, seeing it as lurching from indecisive diplomacy to the brink of invasion. Adversaries might be emboldened, viewing the U.S. government as a paper tiger with a dysfunctional command structure.

Future Changes in International Relations: The outcome would severely damage U.S. hegemony. Alliances like NATO might seek greater strategic autonomy, no longer trusting the U.S. to manage crises effectively. The perception of a weak and divided American government could invite challenges from adversaries in other parts of the world, leading to a period of increased global instability.

6. Key Summary

Scenario Name: Collapse from Within

Key Strategic Choices: An initial U.S. diplomacy-only approach that failed, leading to a catastrophic loss of leadership unity.

Core Progression Summary: A weak opening move by the U.S. led to a political crisis at home. This internal collapse forced a panicked, last-minute swing to a highly aggressive military posture, which in turn prompted a Soviet capitulation.

Final Outcome: War was averted, but the U.S. leadership structure was left shattered, creating a fragile peace vulnerable to internal collapse.

International Reactions: A loss of faith in U.S. leadership, potentially damaging alliances and emboldening adversaries.

Most Important Lesson: In a crisis, the appearance of weakness and indecision can be as dangerous as overt aggression, as it can lead to a loss of political authority that makes a controlled, rational outcome impossible.